becoming one of the leading producers of the Covid vaccine. This was followed by a massively successful vaccination drive that to date has seen over 1.9 billion doses administered, covering most of the adult population. Even US president Joe Biden, at the recent Quad summit in Tokyo, was moved to compliment Modi and India for the handling of the Covid pandemic. In 2021, Modi also infused a massive dose of funds in the health budget to improve infrastructure and to digitise medical records.

But while Covid consumed most of his energies, it did not deter him from speeding up the economic reform process. His finance minister, Nirmala Sitharaman, announced a Rs 20 lakh crore stimulus package to revive the Indian economy, but it was largely to defer loan payments. Only the poor received doles in the form of free grain, lentils and cooking oil. Modi made it sufficiently clear that he was against massive cash transfers to individuals, the course many advanced countries had followed. While many economists criticised his approach, he was vindicated when the subsequent excess liquidity in their economies led to higher inflation in those countries compared to India. Modi then bet big on public expenditure by providing a massive finance boost to infrastructure, particularly road transport. It was meant to revive the core sector, create jobs and stimulate demand by committing Rs 102 lakh crore over a five-year period.

THE FOCUS IN THE REMAINING TWO YEARS OF MODI 2.0 HAS TO BE, AS AN EXPERT PUT IT, "ECONOMY, ECONOMY, ECONOMY"

However, even as he provided short-term relief, particularly to the poor, Modi was busy executing far-reaching economic reform. Within months of the pandemic, he introduced three major farm laws that would free agriculture of state control and inject a large dose of privatisation. The move would subsequently backfire, and Modi would be forced to withdraw the three laws in the face of mounting and sustained protests from farmers. But not before setting the direction of the economy. The big push for privatisation saw what had hitherto been holy cows, like space and atomic energy, opened to private participation. Disinvestment and asset monetisation became the buzzwords, as Air India was finally sold and LIC floated its IPO. Meanwhile, Aatmanirbhar Bharat or self-reliance became the rallying cry in the defence sector, with a Make in India mandate for all major contracts with foreign manufacturers. When the 2021 budget was presented, the document clearly laid down in which areas public sector units would be allowed to continue, with the rest being opened up for privatisation. These were bold and brave reforms resisted even by organisations in the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) fraternity. But Modi refused to relent.

When it came to foreign affairs, Modi was clear that national interests would be safeguarded and advanced while keeping the global good in mind. China's intrusions across the LAC were fiercely resisted with India insisting that ties would not return to normal till status quo ante was restored on the border. Meanwhile, India endorsed the move to revive the Quad grouping, which included the US, Japan and Australia, as a strategic and economic bulwark against China. When Russia invaded Ukraine this February, India refused to be browbeaten by western countries into severing its defence, trade and energy ties with Moscow. It did push for cessation of hostilities and respect for territorial integrity, but abstained from voting on resolutions against Russia in the UN Security Council. The US and other European countries grumbled but did acknowledge that India had to protect its national interests given its dependence on Russian defence supplies.

Realising that foreign investments and exports are critical to India's growth story, Modi has got his team to shed its inhibitions over trade deals and adopt a more give-and-take attitude while signing free trade agreements (FTAs). In a recent breakthrough, India signed FTAs with the UAE and Australia. It is now negotiating with the UK, Canada and Europe on similar trade pacts, while it needs to move swiftly to resolve outstanding issues between India and US on trade matters. An equitable trade agreement is necessary if ties between the two countries have to stay resilient. India recently joined the US-led Indo-Pacific Economic Framework (IPEF), a grouping of 12 other countries in the region, which could act as a counterweight to China on the economic front. Meanwhile, Modi pushed hard to boost India's exports by meeting the whole roster of stakeholders, including over 200 missions and 40 export promotion councils. He then got the commerce ministry to iron out all their concerns. That saw merchandise exports cross the $400 billion mark for the first time in a decade, a growth of 30 per cent over the pre-Covid years.

However, just when India began to turn the economy around, it was buffeted by fresh headwinds. The Ukraine war and the resultant energy and commodity shortage have released inflationary forces and raised the spectre of a global recession. The Modi government moved with alacrity to quell the growing concern over rising prices by cutting petrol and diesel prices and lowering the duty on imported cooking oil. But while this may cool inflationary trends, unemployment continues to be a huge problem.



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